

Colonial North America

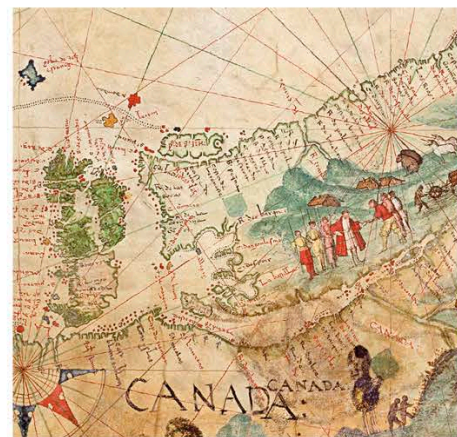
After the voyages of Christopher Columbus to the Caribbean, and Central and South America, Europeans began to become interested in the vast landmass to the north. The first explorers mapped the coasts and rivers of North America. But they were soon followed by Europeans looking to settle on the continent, seeking riches and a fresh start.

As settlements and trading posts grew, more and more Europeans began to sail across the Atlantic Ocean, lured by stories of gold or fertile lands. Many also came in search of a better life, to earn a living, as well as maintain their identity—most notably the English settlers known as the Pilgrims, who set up the Plymouth colony in modern-day Massachusetts in 1620.

But North America was home to many Indigenous communities. As the Europeans began taking native

people's land for their colonies, conflict arose between the two. The deadliest war, fought between English settlers and Indigenous groups led by the Wampanoag people, ended with the colonists killing about 3,000 native people and burning their towns. There were also conflicts between European powers for control over regions.

Despite this, the colonies prospered by trading furs and other products with Europe and growing tobacco, cotton, rice, and grain for export.



▲ EARLY EUROPEAN EXPLORERS

The first European explorer to reach the continent after Columbus was John Cabot. An Italian navigator sent by the king of England, Cabot reached the east coast of Canada in 1497. Later, French explorer Jacques Cartier became the first to map the St. Lawrence River (above) in Canada after making three voyages to the region between 1534 and 1542.



▲ COLONIAL SETTLEMENTS

Over five centuries after the Vikings first made their way to North America, the Spanish set up a trading colony in Florida in 1565. The English set up colonies along the east coast after 1584, while the French began to colonize Canada in 1608. The Dutch colony of New Amsterdam (above), set up in 1626, was captured by the English in 1664. They renamed it New York.

POCAHONTAS

Daughter of a chief of the Powhatan people, Pocahontas (c.1596–1617) was captured by colonists from Jamestown. She later married John Rolfe, an English tobacco planter, and became an ambassador and translator between the two peoples. In 1616, Pocahontas travelled to England where she met King James I and became famous, but she died before the return home.

